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**In search of Pedagogical Heroes:  
What makes practitioners improve  
their pedagogical practice?**

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# In search of Pedagogical Heroes: What makes practitioners improve their pedagogical practice?



*Since I started working in ECEC first as an educational psychologist and later as a researcher, I have been fascinated by the following two questions: what makes people change their practice in order to meet the needs of children and families? And what makes that others are not able to change and are often reproducing the same practice of mediocre quality during their whole career? (Peeters, 1993; Peeters, 2008a; Peeters, Vandebroek, 2011; Peeters, Sharmahd, 2014)*

*The last years I am working as a consultant/researcher in countries in Eastern-Europe, the Caucasus, South-Africa and Vietnam (Peeters, Hulpia, 2018, Peeters, 2019, Declercq, Peeters, 2020). In the different countries where I worked and did field visits, I saw the same phenomenon: for every ECEC centre that gives answers to the challenges of today's society, another ECEC centre reproduces the same low quality practice as years ago. Nevertheless, both services receive a similar financial support from the government.*

*To get an answer to this question related to what makes that individuals and services are open for change, I propose a journey that will lead us from narratives of practitioners that work in innovative services, to inspiring continuous professional development (CPD) paths, and to coherent policy on local, national, and international level.*

*Jan Peeters, Dr., Ghent University*

## Can pedagogical heroes change the system of ECEC?

In the research on professionalism I was involved (Peeters, 2008; ISSA DE-CET, 2012, Peeters, et al, 2016; Sharmahd, et al., 2017) we gathered hundreds of quotes and stories of practitioners from different countries who were seen by colleagues as actors of change. In several studies my colleagues and I were in search of practitioners who were excellent in working in a context of diversity (Peeters, Sharmahd, 2014). We discovered that those actors of change – coming from very

different countries and contexts – were characterized by an amazing personal strength and motivation to change continuously their practice in order to give all children the opportunities they deserve. I would call them pedagogical heroes, because often these teachers are fighting alone against a system that is not open for change.

The strengths and the engagement of these pedagogical heroes are also inspiring for novelists and filmmakers. For example, the touching film of Bernard Tavernier 'Ça commence aujourd'hui' ('It starts today') tells the story of

a director of a small *école maternelle* (Kindergarten) in the North of France. Together with some committed teachers he wants to give poor children food and opportunities. The movie celebrates teachers who fight against the system but unfortunately they fail, because the system is not supporting them.

In Tbilisi, the capital of Georgia, I met such a pedagogical hero in the reality of each day. Her name is Nanuli, she is 70 years old and every year when she wants to retire, the parents protest and they want her to continue, because they think she is excellent in working with them and with their children. She talks to children without raising her voice and all the children are very concentrated working in groups on tasks that fascinate them. For me, Nanuli is another hero of ECEC, she is talented in working with children, she is warm and stimulating in her interactions, she never forces children to learn, but brings them in situations where they are triggered to learn themselves.

Another ECEC hero is Kris, who works mostly with children with a Muslim background in Molenbeek, the municipality where some of the IS terrorists of the Brussels and Paris attacks came from. She has a blog in which she writes about all the problems that this poor municipality within Brussels is facing. After the attacks, when parents felt scared, she was very active in connecting people via social media and she took actions in her classroom to bring parents from different origins again together in this difficult period. Kris is often asked as

speaker on study days and then she explains with passion about the children from Molenbeek.

Another important pedagogical hero for me is definitely Célestin Freinet, the well-known pedagogue. He worked for a long time isolated in the French countryside before he started writing his books. He developed an innovative pedagogy despite the very conservative education system he worked in (Heyerick, 2010).

I am sure that all of you can tell a beautiful story of a similar teacher or pedagogue with strong personal engagement. But one cannot ask from each practitioner/teacher to have this kind of commitment and this courage to challenge a system that is not open for change. These 'pedagogical heroes' can play a major role as actors of change. But sometimes their vision is so different from the one of the traditional school system that they get isolated and go through very difficult periods. Some of them are then confronted with burn out and give up their fight.

### **Many practitioners become actors of change when the system is open for improvement**

Rita is a different type of practitioner. She started to work in the late seventies as a childcare worker in Ghent. In that period childcare centres in Belgium were very child and family unfriendly, very focused on hygiene and medical standards. Later she started working in an excellent day care centre with a lot of autonomy, inspiring pedagogical leadership and excellent pedagogical coaching. At the end of her ca-

reer she became one of the best child-care workers I know. In a video we made about her she looks back at her years in that very hierarchical and child unfriendly centre. The interview with Rita (Peeters, 2008a, p. 100-102) shows that when professionalism is defined in a narrow way (like it is still in many countries) then institutions can impose practitioners a practice which is harmful for young children. In the film she gives examples of how babies were treated as objects and were lacking warm interactions due to a purely medical and hygienical vision. However, this interview shows that practitioners really have the capacity to become actors of change if they get the right support. Rita says in the interview that, after many years of pedagogical support and coaching: 'They could never let me do this again'.

Katrien Van Laere came to the same conclusion in her research in Flanders on the transition of second language learners to kindergarten at the age of 2.5 years old (Van Laere, 2017). This research underlines how a narrow interpretation of professionalism can impact practitioners/teachers. As a result, for example, some teachers do not see caring tasks as a part of their professional identity:

*"If I also have to start caring for children individually, that is too much."*

*"People expect you to hug the children. I don't think this is my task. I am not the mother."*

Other teachers experience the care tasks as important, but they consider them more as a personal characteristic ('I like to hug children') then as a part of their profession.

*"I'm more a mother than a teacher in working with the young children in preschool."*

*"But I'm a cuddly person and the children know this and are used to this."*

(Van Laere, 2017)

These narratives illustrate what the Core and Eurofound research concluded: being competent is not the sole responsibility of the practitioner, we need a competent system that supports practitioners, and that provides the right coaching to implement this within a broad holistic interpretation of professionalism (Vandenbroeck, et al., 2016; Peeters, et al., 2015).

### **Towards Professional Learning Communities (PLCs): which characteristics?**

This raises the question about what kind of CPD can introduce a process of change (even in rigid ECEC systems) on the level of the institution (Peeters, et al, 2015, Peleman et al.2018). In other words, if we look at centres of excellent quality where every practitioner is involved in a continuous process of change, what are the characteristics of these centres? How are they organized on an institutional level? Professional Learning Communities (PLCs) can be an answer in this direction.

VVOB Education for Development has experimented in their project in South Africa with PLC's. For VVOB "PLC's are communities that provide the setting and necessary support for groups of teachers, school managers and trainers and education officials to participate collectively in determining their own developmental trajectories, and to set up activities that will drive their development'. The essential ingredients of effective PLC's are needs driven, mutual trust, collective responsibility, support from common principles, facilitator skills and input of experts (VVOB, 2017).

In a recent study for NESET, a network of researchers on inclusive education from the European Commission, we have studied critical factors that are crucial to create PLCs (Sharmahd, et al.,2017).

As Figure 1 shows, in order to improve the quality of learning and well-being for children and families, a competent system is needed. In a competent system a professional learning community can grow, when the following specific characteristics are present (Vanblaere, 2016):

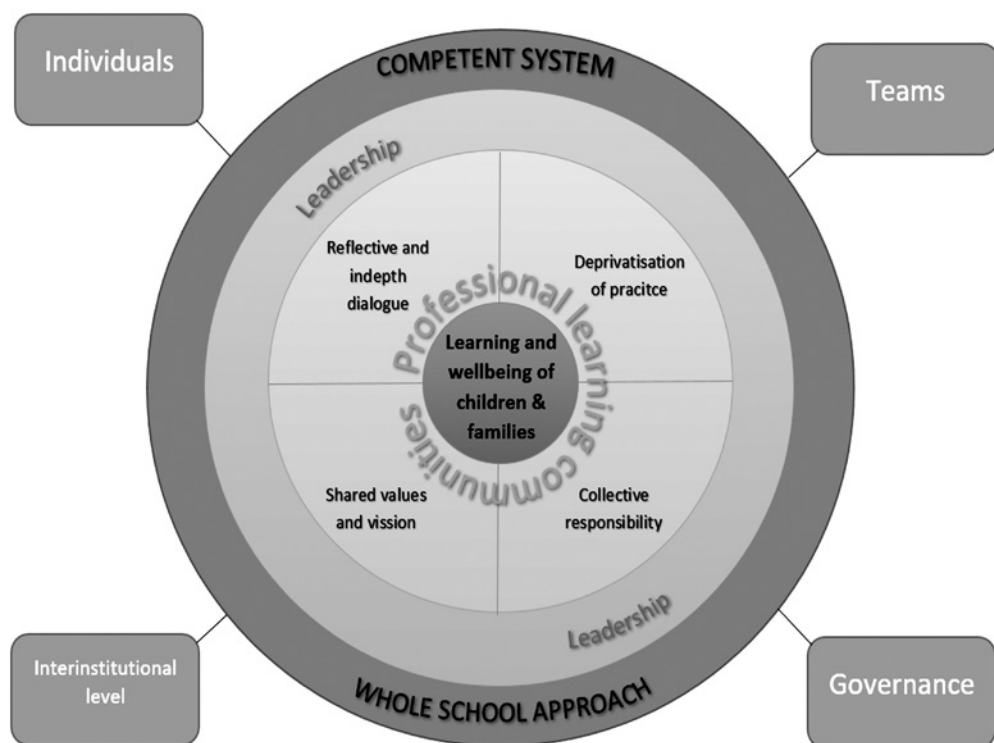


Figure 1 – PLC – Source: Sharmahd, Peeters, Van Laere, Vonta, De Kimpe, Brajković, Contini, Giovannini (2017). *Transforming European ECEC services and schools into professional learning communities: drivers, barriers and ways forward NESSET*. Luxemburg, Publication Office of European Union.

1. **Teachers frequently engage in ‘reflective and in-depth dialogues’** with colleagues about educational matters based on daily practice.
2. **Teachers move from the classroom doors in a ‘deprivatization of practices’**, by observing each other’s practice, giving feedback, joint planning, relationship with the neighbourhood, dialogue with parents.
3. **There is investment in ‘collective responsibility’**, as school improvement is not considered anymore as solely the responsibility of the principal or of a single teacher, but as a collective one.
4. **There is a focus on reaching shared values and vision**, based on children rights and respect towards diversity.
5. These four characteristics need a fifth condition to be realized. This condition is **the presence of ‘leadership’** as a powerful strength in transforming schools’ culture.

The case studies of the NESET report show how these principles can be realized in practice in different ways. The voices of practitioners/teachers from Italy (Pistoia), Belgium (Ghent, Brussels), Croatia and Slovenia point out what are important characteristics of continuous professional development to create a culture of learning in teams and institutions. We also add results of the VVOB reports, because they use PLC’s to make a very hierarchical top down system of education more democratic by focusing on the mediating layer of education officials.

In the following pages we describe more in detail each PLC characteristic.

### *3.1 Reflecting on pedagogical practice and in-depth dialogue with colleagues*

The first characteristic is reflecting on pedagogical practice and in-depth dialogue with colleagues in order to clarify explicit and implicit assumptions and beliefs, and to develop together new pedagogical practices (Verbiest, 2008, Vanblaere, 2016). As Peter Moss underlines, Malaguzzi would talk about ‘formazione’ instead of CPD. This long time coaching through ‘formazione’ or ‘auto-formazione’ has resulted in high quality services in many cities in Northern Italy (Moss, 2018). For the NESET Italian case study we studied the outstanding CPD system in Pistoia. In the interviews the practitioners make the link between their excellent quality and a bottom-up approach, based on co-reflecting on practice within teams and institutions. They argue for a constant collective discussion on practice (Giovannini, Contini, 2017).

The ISSA DECET study (2012) clearly illustrates this characteristic with quotes from practitioners:

*“We have to be brave enough to question our own views and professional practice and to be aware of the importance of equal opportunities for each child and family.” (France)*

*“I changed my practice thanks to working side by side with the Roma teaching assistant. The biggest change was that I started listening and hearing before making decisions or judgements” (Serbia)*

In the VVOB project in South Africa PLC's are also successfully used for directors of schools and for officials of the education department (Peeters, Declercq, 2020):

*"PLCs have given opportunities to reflect on our practice, this is unique" (school leader)*

*"Through the reflections inside the PLCs the participants have undergone a change of mind set and it created enthusiasm for the process of change" (official of Teacher Development Directorate)*

Sanja Brajkovic from Croatia, who was also involved in the NESET study (2017), holds a plea for a bottom up approach (Brajkovic, 2014) to give answers to the challenges of our continuously changing society. There is a consensus in the research world to advocate for the active involvement of practitioners in the process of improving the quality through reflecting on practice (Brajkovic, 2014; Peeters, et al., 2015).

### 3.2 Deprivatization of teaching practices

Several scholars and international organisations are questioning the traditional model of schooling that still exists in most of our countries.

*"Traditional models of schooling whose organisational patterns deeply structure schools (the single teacher, the classroom segmented from other classrooms each with their own teacher, traditional approaches to teaching and classroom organiza-*

*tion, etc.) are inadequate for [...] the 21<sup>st</sup> learning agendas, especially for the most disadvantaged students in society."*

*(Kools, Stoll, 2016, OECD, Working Papers 12.)*

Therefore the researchers are arguing for a second characteristic to create a culture of learning among teachers: the 'deprivatization of teaching practices'. Teachers move from the classroom doors, by observing each other's practice, giving feedback, joint planning, dialogue with parents and with the neighbourhood (Lomos, et al, 2011; Wahstromand, Louis, 2008). The Belgian case study in the NESET report shows an example of deprivatisation of pedagogical practice in Elmer, a group of childcare centers in the poorest neighbourhoods of Brussels (Peeters, De Kimpe, 2017).

*"We learn constantly from each other and to each other, from the parents, our colleagues and from the children. We learn by stealing from the others." (Elmer childcare worker)*

Elmer also provides trainings on the work floor and succeeds to get low qualified women from ethnic background qualified through adapted pathways. Recently some of them graduated in the new bachelor degree for childcare. Thanks to their experience in training on the workplace, giving feedback to each other in daily practice became a natural attitude. The team has a longstanding tradition of 'open doors and open minds'. Elmer

was involved in a European Erasmus project, that used job shadowing (working in a centre in another European country for one week). The experiences of the childcare workers from Elmer with job shadowing in Latvia, Portugal, Slovenia, Italy and Sweden were very positive.

*“We learned so much on involving parents through Jobshadowing in Latvia, Portugal, Slovenia, Italy and Sweden.” (Elmer childcare worker)*

This exchange has inspired the parental participation of Elmer: the childcare workers discovered new ways of involving parents. The families of Elmer appreciated very much those new initiatives (Peeters, De Kimpe, 2017).

In the VVOB project in South Africa they also work with the principle of deprivatization of practice:

*“PLCs bring teachers together that teach the same subjects. They discuss, share good practices... they even help one another in terms of lesson plans and preparations. It's peer education. The one teacher teaches the other and that gives confidence. I really love it. Within the PLCs we now have started with a lesson study approach, where teachers visit each other's lessons, observe and come up with advices. And when the teacher feels confident enough, he gets another visit (Education department official)”.*

### 3.3. Collective responsibility

A third characteristic of an innovative ECEC centre is that they invest in ‘collective responsibility’: school improvement is not considered anymore as solely the responsibility of the principal or of a single teacher, but as a collective one (Stoll, et al. 2006; Vanblaere, 2016). As an answer to the teacher who acts alone in her classroom, different approaches are put forward: collegiality in the Northern-Italian approach (Giovannini,Contini, 2017) and cooperation in the Freinet pedagogy (Heyerick, 2010). Many other approaches of collective responsibility exist, that starts from the awareness that learning in your job happens through relationships: by exchanging, or negotiating different points of view within a team, by ‘working together’ with attention to the individuals, the groups, the community. This ‘collegiality’, is the basis of the professional identity of ECEC in Pistoia as in other North Italian towns. Collegiality creates coherence, with the aim of increasing the wellbeing of children and families (Musatti, et al., 2016) . Within this collegiality approach, in Pistoia pedagogical coordination or coaching is crucial , in order to better understand the languages of the children, their social interactions, their ways of exploring the world and it is also a source of inspiration for the communication with families. Investing in a ‘collegial approach’ in which the practitioners/ teachers’ job is recognized and valued creates a ‘constructive circle’ in which staff motivation grows. (Musatti, et al., 2016)

An important principle of the Freinet pedagogy is cooperation. For the NESET research we studied the competent system in De Vlieger (Dutch for 'the Kite'), a Freinet school in a deprived area in Ghent with a mix of families with an ethnic minority, disadvantaged and middle class background. For example, the Vlieger involves the older children who speak the same language in caring for the new children from ethnic minorities. It is a project in which children are heard, and teachers are questioned and actively involved in the decision making process. The Vlieger has weekly team meetings, which are the motor for this collective responsibility: giving feedback, deploying the expertise of each member of the team, and supporting each other if necessary. (Peeters, De Kimpe, 2017)

In Croatia and Slovenia the project on professional learning communities (Tankersley, 2018; Vonta, 2015, 2016) was evaluated and the participants of the project found that developing a 'collective story' was a critical factor for success. The participants considered that it is crucial to build a sense of community through appreciation of colleagues, building trust in the team, be open among colleagues and work in group without stress. Considering the influence on the institutional level, participants mostly recognize positive changes in the institutional climate, and in the capacity of building a shared vision of quality.

In South Africa education officials describe the effect of collective responsibility within the PLC's as follows (Peeters, Declercq, 2020):

*"Where there is a PLC we noted some change. There is ownership in terms of the decisions they take." (education official)*

*"PLCs bring people from different education sections together. This is highly effective. People within districts are now working together. They did a needs analysis as a team and then raised the question "what can this or that sub-directorate do?" They planned as a district instead of from separate directorates. They were forced to work together. This model was kickstarting and gets it rolling" (education official)*

### 3.4. Shared values and vision

The fourth principle is the focus on reaching shared values and vision, which forms the basis for collective, and ethical decision making (Whalstrom, Louis, 2008). De Vlieger, Elmer, the centres in Pistoia and the ISSA centres in Slovenia and Croatia all work on the basis of an 'inclusive belief' according to which each child, despite any obstacles, is able to learn and should be supported in doing so. This is interwoven with what we before defined here as collective responsibility, since a base of shared child centred values focused on equity can culminate in a sense of collective responsibility (Sharmahd, et al. 2017). The director of the Vlieger emphasises the added value of the common vision about the Freinet pedagogy, which is a source of inspiration and a guidance for the school's daily pedagogical practice.

The case studies in Slovenia and Croatia have also a common vision and shared values: the ISSA Quality Resource Pack, that inspires the professional learning communities in their daily work (ISSA, 2009, 2015).

From the evaluation of the VVOB project in South Africa we learned the PLC's can play an important role in developing a common vision towards inclusive education (Peeters, Declercq, 2020)

### *3.5. Leadership as a powerful strength in transforming schools culture*

These four characteristics need a fifth condition to be realized. This condition is 'leadership as a powerful strength in transforming schools' culture (Vanblaere, 2016). The latter is not an innovation to be implemented, but rather a new culture to be developed (Fullan, 2016, p 20). The director of the Vlieger for instance sees her role as stimulating and coaching her collaborators towards change that improves quality (Peeters, de Kimpe, 2017). Stimulating exchange of experiences, collaboration and cooperation are for her important points of attention. In her role she always tries to recognize and use the talents of each collaborator. She emphasises the role of individual talks, formal (like performance talks) but especially informal. Coaching is crucial for breaking through the fixed habits and introducing new pedagogical practice. It is also important to optimise the quality of the teaching and to follow up what has been decided in the team. The important roles of a director are: being an excellent organiser, being able to recognize the needs of parents

and children, being able to listen, being focused on consultation, coaching teachers who are not performing well, being able to take decisions when there is no consensus in the team (Vandenaabeele, In Peeters, de Kimpe, 2017).

In 2015 I visited the NGO Balkan Sunflowers, learning centre in Fushe-Kosova, a school for Roma children in Kosovo (Peeters, 2016). The living conditions for the Roma children are very difficult, the settlement is far away from the nearest town, the families live in extreme poverty and the older children are working in garbage collection. But inside the ECEC school there is such a warm climate and children get opportunities to show their strengths. When receiving visitors from Western Europe, for instance five year olds translate the conversation between the guests and the Roma children from French and German to Romani. What stroked me was the warm interaction and the engagement of all the educators who worked with the Roma kids. Through this commitment they create a safe place for the children, a place that made them eager to learn. The kids of Sunflowers were very concentrated in their activities. I also met the municipal education director of Fushe-Kosova and the director of Balkan Sunflowers, and then I understood that the secret of the Sunflower learning centre was the combination of the inspiring leadership of the director and the concrete support of the local government through the commitment of the educational director of Fushe-Kosova municipality.

*Can PLC's work in making hierarchical top down systems more democratic?*

The evaluation of the VVOB project in South Africa proves that even in hierarchical top down systems, PLC's can introduce a more democratic and participatory culture on the higher levels of the competent education system. Methods like PLC's succeeded not only in increasing agency of the teacher and the school leader but the officials also get more agency in their role in spite of the hierarchical system. VVOB succeeded in doing this by targeting the mediating layer (officials, coaches) and transforming the mediating layer into actors of change. This participatory approach of the PLC's creates ownership of the change among the stakeholders. This was in the VVOB project very effective because the mediating layer has the mandate to train and coach teachers and school leaders, support schools, facilitate the sharing of improvements across schools, translate and interpret national policy guidelines, and they can serve as advocates to the national level. With PLC's that focus on the mediating layer, it seems to be possible to combine a bottom up and a top down approach: through the PLC's it was possible to change the beliefs about what quality education means towards both: policymakers and teachers. So we can conclude that PLC's can be a powerful tool to develop a competent ECE system (Peeters, Declercq, 2020).

## **Collaboration between policymakers and practitioners**

### *4.1 We had a dream that came true*

I like to go back in time to one of the most inspiring periods in my career as educational psychologist and researcher. In the beginning of the eighties the birth rates in Belgium went down. In the city of Ghent, because of the low quality of the pre-primary and primary schools, every year the schools lost around 250 pupils. The two co-ordinators of the Pedagogical Guidance centre were pedagogues who did their PhD on inclusive education and wanted to create new schools of high quality. Therefore, every first Friday of the month they organized a meeting with around 30 practitioners, educational psychologists, civil servants and researchers to brainstorm about the ideal school and the ideal childcare centre. It was an amazing experience, we discussed on pedagogical principles, but we also drew and designed the building of our imaginary school and childcare centre. Peter Moss gave a beautiful name to this approach towards change: Utopian Thinking (Moss, 2007:243). These were exciting times for all of us, we learned a lot of each other's dreams and the results of our work were published in the magazine of the city schools, so that all the teachers and childcare workers were informed about our work. The directors of the Pedagogical Guidance centre proposed the results of our work to the Aldermen and two years later our dreams became reality: the first Freinet school opened the doors (Heyerick, 2010) and today there are 13

Freinet schools in Ghent. These sessions on the ideal ECEC centre and school had also an important impact on continuous professional development policy within the childcare centres of the city of Ghent. The impact of those CPD initiatives have been extensively documented by reports, articles and videos (Peeters, 1993; Peeters, 2008a) and in an UNESCO case study: (Peeters, Vandenbroeck, 2010). As part of the CoRe research, a case study on the municipal childcare system in Ghent was conducted (Peeters, De Kimpe & Brandt, 2016). This case study concluded that practitioners learn best when they operate in a competent system. This is characterised by a coherent multi-layered and diversified policy towards CPD, during a sustained period of time, supported by specialised pedagogical counsellors. An important critical success factor is the ownership of the change, which must be shared within the ECEC centres. The competent system of the city of Ghent is furthermore characterised by a common culture on different levels of the system. This culture is underpinned by a common vision, by ethical values towards children, parents, colleagues and the neighbourhood. It strives for social change on all levels of the competent system.

#### *4.2. The intersection between research/training, policy, practice*

So it is important that researchers, trainers, policymakers and practitioners meet each other and think out of the box to find answers for new challenges. New Zealand is also very inspiring for this collaboration inside the

triangle practice, research/training and policymaking (Peeters, 2008b). The ECEC sector in New Zealand has a long tradition going back to the eighties of continuous dialogue between practitioners, policymakers, trainers and researchers. This tradition of close collaboration was very successful and gave birth to excellent quality frameworks like the multicultural curriculum TeWhariki and the development of a Code of Ethics. It was also very innovative for the professionalization of the workforce. Thanks to a successful ten year strategic plan, the qualification level of most staff members has been increased to bachelor level (also those working with the 0 to 3-year-olds group).

Another interesting example of an approach that works on the intersection between research/training, policy and practice are the VVOB programmes Education for Development in Vietnam and South-Africa. The external evaluators concluded that both projects succeeded in both countries in increasing agency of the teacher, the school leader and the officials in spite of the hierarchical system. (Declercq, Peeters 2020). They succeeded in doing this by targeting the mediating layer and transforming them into actors of change through professional learning communities (PLC's). This participatory approach of VVOB creates ownership of the change among the stakeholders. In this way VVOB creates a motivated group that advocate for the change themselves. This was very effective because the mediating layer has the mandate to train and coach teachers and school leaders, support schools,

facilitate the sharing of improvements across schools, translate and interpret national policy guidelines, and they can serve as advocates to the national level. By focusing on the mediating layer, it seems to be possible to combine a bottom up and a top down approach: the scientific inspired VVOB programmes succeeded in changing the beliefs about what quality ECE and primary education means towards policymakers and towards teachers. (Peeters, Declercq, 2020).

#### *4.3. The importance of the international level*

The international level plays an increasing role since the launching by the United Nations of the Sustainable Developmental Goals (2015-2030). SDG 4 wants to “Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all”. It incorporates for the first time ECEC: TARGET 4.2 “By 2030, ensure that all girls and boys have access to quality early childhood development, care and pre-primary education so that they are ready for primary education”. TARGET 4.c on Teachers is also a source for many projects and initiatives on CPD for teachers: “By 2030, substantially increase the supply of qualified teachers.” Thanks to these SDG targets we see that international organisations take initiatives to help countries to improve the teacher training and CPD. We think of the UNESCO International Task Force on teachers Education, that organized meetings on teacher training in ECEC in Lomé, Togo in 2017 and in Montego Bay in Jamaica in 2018. Several projects on increasing professional-

ism of ECEC workers were set up by UNICEF in many countries and there were also tools developed by UNICEF on the topic of teacher training in ECEC (Peeters, et al, 2019, Hyson, et al 2019). The European Commission also set up a ECEC Working Group (2018-2020). OECD is also taking initiatives to strengthen the ECEC workforce with conferences and publications (OECD, 2019).

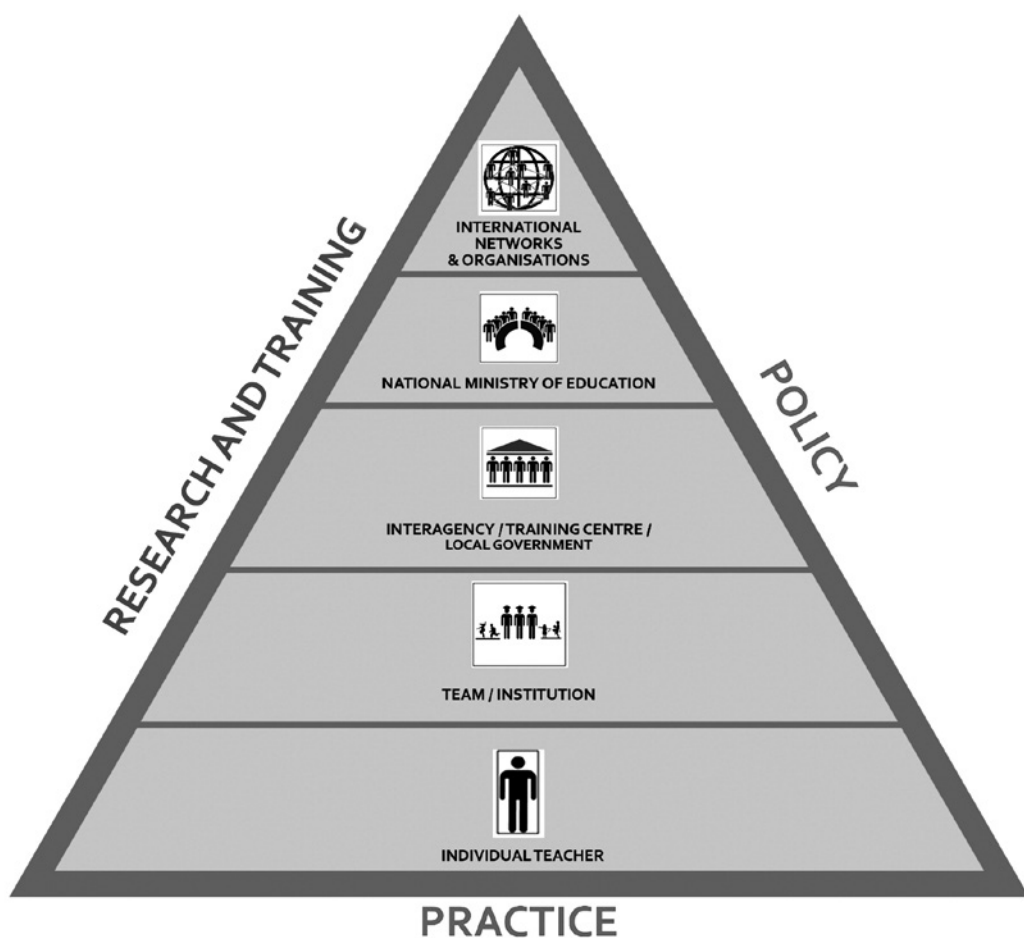
In Serbia a new pre-school curriculum Framework called ‘Years of Ascent’ was developed by a group of policymakers, trainers, researchers and stakeholders. With the collaboration of the governmental organisations and UNICEF this group succeeded in making one of the more innovative curriculums on ECEC (Peeters, Miskeljin, 2018). The success is due to the intense collaboration between the Institute for Pedagogy and Andragogy of the University of Belgrade, policymakers and practitioners and international organisations like UNICEF.

Another interesting example of the impact of international organisations is Georgia, where with the support of UNICEF an analysis of the quality of ECEC was done by using focus groups and a survey in each local community. One of the results was that there was a need for a new initial training on bachelor level and more focus on coaching in CPD. A year later UNICEF brought the universities together to reflect together on proposals of training competence profile for the initial training and UNICEF is also looking for a method of coaching that stimulates the reflection on practice (Peeters, Hulpia, Janelidze, et al., 2018).

## 5. Recommendations: towards a competent system within the triangle research/training, policy and practice

We can conclude that the recent research on what kind of CPD is effective is quite convincing and professional learning community is one of this efficient forms of CPD. But research in education is not a purpose in itself, but a tool to change and improve the pedagogical practice and the policy in ECEC. Although policymakers, practi-

tioners, trainers and researchers often seem to speak a different language (Milotay, 2016), they need to be rewarded as inextricable when we want to realize sustainable change. Neither ECEC researchers, nor trainers nor practitioners or policymakers alone have the full array of knowledge and skills to move effectively from established principles to specific plans of action to improve the quality of practice in ECEC.



(Core, 2011; Peeters, 2018)

We can conclude from the research on PLC's and from the narratives in this article that the closer the cooperation of research, training, policy and practice is in the system of continuous professional development, the better the results on the long term are (Peeters & Peleman, 2017). PLC's seem to be an effective CPD method to translate research results in a democratic way into meaningful and supportive practice for practitioners and even for policymakers.

The final recommendation is that the ECEC sector needs more pedagogical heroes, which have the power to improve the living conditions of disadvantaged children. But these individual courageous practitioners need support from all levels of the competent system. And again PLC's have proved to be effective to develop the necessary competences on all levels of the ECEC system to work with the most disadvantaged children and families. Therefore we need to invest in a competent system of ECEC that enables the practitioners to give local responses to global challenges.

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